Co-Creation with AI: Artistic Practices as Critical Laboratories

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ABSTRACT The integration of artificial intelligence into artistic practices is profoundly transforming contemporary creation. Artists no longer merely consider AI as a tool but employ it as a co-creator, experimental medium, and object of critique. Through a focused corpus of artistic works, this article aims to examine how the use of AI in art reveals and anticipates the ethical, social, and epistemological tensions it generates, while highlighting the role of art as a critical laboratory for extended intelligences. The reflection centers on the redefinition of authorship and creativity, as well as the question of intellectual property, by analyzing human-machine co-creation and works as cognitive hybridizations in which human intention engages in dialogue with algorithmic generation. It also explores ethical and social issues by showing how certain works expose the biases, subjectivity, and cultural impact of the datasets that train AI systems. Artists interrogate the cultural and historical assumptions embedded in these data, and their interventions can critique or subvert these structures. Moreover, AI-mediated artistic practices offer a privileged perspective for considering the social and epistemological consequences of extended intelligences. By simulating memory, perception, and interpretation, these works prompt a reconsideration of how knowledge is generated, archived, and shared, as well as the potential for co-evolution between humans and computational agents. The corpus includes the work of Anna Ridler, Albertine Meunier, Olivain Porry, Trevor Paglen and Kate Crawford, whose practices exemplify these dynamics. Their experimentation demonstrates that art functions as a critical laboratory addressing ethical, social, and epistemological challenges. Beyond serving as a tool, AI operates as a medium revealing broader implications of hybrid intelligences, suggesting new models of collaboration, responsibility, and agency within human–machine ecosystems. By approaching AI through the lens of artistic practice, this study argues that art constitutes a true laboratory of critical ethics, a space where the boundaries of agency, transparency, and authorship are continuously renegotiated.

Introduction

In October 2018, the auction of the *Portrait of Edmond de Belamy* by the collective Obvious brought to public attention the issues at stake in the relationship between art and artificial intelligence. Created using a generative adversarial network (GAN) [1] and sold for $432,500 at Christie's, the work sparked intense controversy regarding its conditions of production and the attribution of its creative authority. Marketed according to the traditional codes of the art market while being presented as the creation of an "autonomous intelligence", it obscured the collective and procedural nature of the process, as the authorship of the algorithm and of the original training dataset was not clearly attributed to Obvious (Allard, 2021). This debate on the auctoriality of the work – located within the code, the network architecture, or the learning model – resonates with the structural opacity of artificial neural networks, whose decision-making processes largely escape human understanding, even that of their designers. This opacity, often described as a "black box", refers to the impossibility of tracing all the parameters that lead an algorithm to produce a given result within an artificial intelligence system (Crawford & Paglen, 2021). Such unintelligibility raises major issues of responsibility, trust, and power in technical, cultural, and social spheres (Ackerman et al., 2025). Approximately one year after the debate surrounding the sale of Obvious's work, the exhibition "Training Humans", conceived by AI researcher and professor Kate Crawford and artist and researcher Trevor Paglen, contributed to making this invisible dimension of artificial intelligence visible by exploring the logics of sorting, recognition, and normalization underlying the construction of visual datasets and their training [2]. When considered in tandem, the controversies surrounding the *Portrait of Edmond de Belamy* and the exhibition "Training Humans" underscore the significance of self-reflexivity in AI-inte-

[1] - Generative adversarial networks are a type of artificial intelligence system composed of two neural networks working in opposition. The first, known as the generator, produces synthetic images; the second, known as the discriminator, evaluates whether those images appear real or artificial. Through this back-and-forth process, the generator gradually improves until its outputs become difficult to distinguish from actual images, making GANs one of the primary tools used in AI-generated image production (Goodfellow et al., 2014).

Didascalia immagine di apertura senza numero, allineata in basso [IBM Plex Sans Condensed , 9pt, interlinea 10,8pt, giustificato (ultima riga allineata a sinistra)].

grated visual art. Consequently, artificial intelligence transcends its role as a mere instrument, becoming an object of artistic and critical inquiry, a space in which notions of authorship, control, and transparency are re-enacted. Self-reflexivity can be traced as early as the first generative artworks of the 1960s and 1970s, subsequently intensifying through successive technological transformations that, by gradually integrating into all areas of society, give rise to new issues and consequences. In this sense, the digital can be understood as a "boundary object" (Coron, 2022; Star & Griesemer, 1989), simultaneously technical and social, through which artists reformulate our ways of seeing, narrating, and understanding the world.

Aims and objectives

Building on the premise of the digital as a boundary object, and in continuity with the reflections surrounding the controversy of *Portrait of Edmond de Belamy* and the exhibition "Training Humans", this research examines how certain artworks are conceived as genuine critical laboratories, capable of performing self-reflexivity on their use of artificial intelligence. The aim is to analyze the extent to which these works mobilize AI simultaneously as a medium, a field of research, and an object of inquiry, in order to question its aesthetic, cultural, and social implications, thereby contributing to the construction of a computational epistemology of the twenty-first century. The general hypothesis rests on the idea that the notion of the laboratory, as articulated by Jean-Paul Fourmentraux (Fourmentraux & Menger, 2011), developed with the integration of digital technologies within visual art in the twentieth century and made more visible by the acceleration of digital processes in the twenty-first century, gains a critical dimension with the democratization and performativity of artificial intelligence. Since the rise of deep learning [3], and particularly since the use of GANs in the 2010s, the democratization of artificial intelligence tools and the proliferation of voluminous datasets have reinforced this self-reflexive dimension. The scope of artistic practice, far from being limited to a formal experimentation with artificial intelligence, aligns with a critical corpus addressing technological systems and their effects, while simultaneously contributing to ongoing research on artificial neural networks.

Procedure

Combining qualitative and analytical approaches, this study draws on a corpus of artworks engaging artificial intelligence in a self-reflexive dimension, with a primary focus on convolutional neural networks (CNNs) [4] and generative adversarial networks (GANs). The corpus is organized into two distinct groups. The first encompasses *Adversarially Evolved Hallucinations* (2017) by Trevor Paglen (b. 1974) and Myriad Tulips (2018) by Anna Ridler (b. 1985), which illuminate the ways in which artists probe the technical structures of AI in order to produce a reflexivity directed at the tool itself. The second group comprises *ImageNet Roulette* (2019) by Kate Crawford (b. 1974) and Trevor Paglen, and *Slop Machine* (2025) by Albertine Meunier (b. 1964) and Olivain Porry, which, by diverting existing data flows, lay bare the biases embedded within artificial intelligence systems and their implications for the contemporary regime of the image. Each work is examined at the intersection of form, production process, and documentary research, with a view to identifying shared logics that underpin what this study designates as the paradigm of the critical laboratory (Table 1).

Results

The laboratory constitutes both a real space of collaboration and tension (Fourmentraux & Menger, 2011), and a metaphorical site of research and speculation at the heart of the creative act, aiming to translate and render visible an image of the world (Fleischer, 2015). These facets can be observed in the works of artists who select or modify machine learning models, construct or subvert their datasets, or manipulate training data. This use of artificial intelligence establishes a dialectic of cooperation, or even antagonism, with the machine, generating, at

[2] - "Training Humans", from 12 September 2019 to 24 February 2020, at the Fondazione Prada, Venice, Italy.

[3] - Drawing on the foundational work of LeCun, Bengio and Hinton (LeCun et al., 2015), deep learning can be defined as a subset of machine learning in which artificial neural networks composed of multiple processing layers autonomously learn hierarchical representations of data, enabling the recognition of complex patterns without explicit human programming.

[4] - Convolutional neural networks are a type of artificial intelligence system trained to "see" and interpret images. Rather than analysing an image as a whole, a CNN scans it in successive steps, identifying increasingly complex visual elements, first basic features such as edges and colours, then shapes, and finally recognisable objects. (Krizhevsky et al., 2017; Lecun et al., 1998).

Critical Laboratory Paradigm: Four Artworks in Dialogue	Critical Laboratory Paradigm: Four Artworks in Dialogue			
	Adversarially Evolved Hallucinations Trevor Paglen, 2017	**Myriad (Tulips) Anna Ridler, 2018**	**ImageNet Roulette Crawford & Paglen, 2019**	**Slop Machine Meunier & Porry, 2025**
Relationship to AI as medium				
Model Used	GAN — Latent spaces explored	GAN — Custom hand-annotated dataset	CNN — Existing ImageNet classifier	LLM (multimodal) — Automated Instagram feed
Dataset construction	Own corpus — Curated allegorical images	Own corpus — 10,000 photographed tulips	Existing dataset — ImageNet repurposed	Real-time feed — Live Internet slop captured
Critical Dimension of the laboratory				
Opacity / black box	● Making neural network hallucinations visible	● Materialising the labelling process	◑ Revealing ImageNet's hidden categories	◑ Exposing algorithmic engagement mechanics
Bias & normativity	◑ Ideological bias in training corpora	● Subjectivity of classification (Ronald Fisher's Iris dataset)	● Racism, sexism embedded in labels	● Hypernudging & cognitive saturation
Invisible labour	○ Marginal	◑ Handcraft foregrounded; visible corrections	● Click workers; precarity denounced	◑ Automation vs. human judgement
Questioning the real	● Non-existent images; new visual regimes	◑ Data as interpretation, never neutral	◑ Algorithmic objectivity as illusion	● Post-truth; blurring authentic / artificial
Laboratory modality				
Integration in exhibition	Photography / print	Photographic installation	Interactive installation and web application	Interactive installation
Mode of Experience (viewer's role)	Contemplative	Contemplative	Active — submits own face	Active — judges each image
Epistemological scope	Perception — New forms of machine vision	Knowledge — Classification as power	Political — Systemic discrimination	Political — Attention economy

Table 1 - Critical Laboratory Paradigm: Four Artworks in Dialogue. Comparative synthesis across three dimensions: relationship to AI as medium, critical dimensions of the laboratory, and exhibition modality. Visual indicators (●/◑/○) signal the degree of presence of each critical dimension within the work. Author's own elaboration.

the same time, new forms of representation. Rooted in the lineage of computer art and the early experiments conducted at the Centre Universitaire de Vincennes or at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) [5], these processes of artistic experimentation with AI amplify the dialectic of the laboratory. They question the status of the image and the notion of the real, as well as the functioning of machine learning models. They also interrogate the systems of automation and normalization characteristic of contemporary digital culture, along with the political and social structures and the associated biases conveyed through artificial intelligence.

Anatomy of Image Automation

In the exhibition "Training Humans", one of the core objectives is to trace the history of images used for human recognition in computer vision and artificial intelligence systems [6]. This narrative involves understanding the automation of cognition that artificial intelligence addresses by performing increasingly complex tasks, an objective that has animated computer research since its inception. Through this automation, artificial intelligence makes image creation more accessible and multiplies its occurrences, profoundly transforming the regime of images. Moreover, the generated images are previously non-existent (Combette, 2025) ; rather than capturing reality, they aggregate it into algorithms, thereby contributing to the construction of a new reality and producing models to which the real must adapt (Steyerl et al., 2021) [7].

In his series, *Adversarially Evolved Hallucinations* created in 2017, Trevor Paglen seeks to understand the invisible automated operations that lead to these new representations and induce a modification of reality. He trains GANs on his own datasets composed of allegorical, metaphorical, and symbolic images, identified from literary, philosophical, folkloric, and historical references. In V*ampire (Corpus: Monster of Capitalism)*, for instance, the image produced derives from his "Monster of Capitalism" corpus, composed of creatures (zombies, vampires, werewolves) used metaphorically to critique capitalism; the figure of the vampire also evokes the extractivist potential of AI. In this process, Paglen does not merely aim to generate an image from the curated corpus; he also explores latent spaces (Ackerman et al., 2025). Antonio Somaini defines the latent space as the virtual space constructed during the training of machine learning models, where images are converted into probabilistic vectors. Since the 2010s, artists have explored and modified latent spaces to propose alternative uses, revealing the automated dimension of a new form of perception generated by artificial intelligence and the control it exerts over visual culture [8]. By selecting images from the latent spaces explored by the model, Paglen produces blurred and hybrid images that, according to him, embody the "hallucinations" of artificial neural networks. Through the generation of new images, he exposes to viewers a glimpse of the internal and invisible mechanisms of AI models, thereby contributing to reducing the opacity that surrounds these systems. In this sense, for the artist, creating his own dataset reintroduces reflexivity toward the tool, often lost in the immediacy of the prompt but reactivated through artistic practice.

By automating creation and aesthetic choices, artificial intelligence contributes to the transformation of cultural behaviors and, through form-generating systems, promotes a homogenization and standardization of images at the expense of aesthetic diversity (Manovich, 2018; Zocco & Kyrou, 2020). In her work *Myriad (Tulips)*, created in 2018, Anna Ridler explores the implications of image automation by seeking to make visible the mechanisms of standardized databases used in machine learning, adopting an approach opposite to their original functioning. Ridler builds a dataset from tulips that she photographs, selects, identifies, and annotates manually, thus reproducing by hand the process of data collection and image classification used in machine learning systems. *Myriad (Tulips)* becomes both a technical tool [9] and an artwork, an epistemological device in which the dataset is not merely a technical prerequisite but becomes the central object of reflection. In doing so, Ridler questions the contemporary conditions of meaning, knowledge, and representation production, while situating her work within the history of classification systems aimed at ordering the world (Carey, 2021) [10]. By

[5] - The Vincennes Art and Computer Science Group (GAIV), was formed in 1969 within the Computer Science Department at the Centre Universitaire de Vincennes bringing together researchers, computer science students, visual art students, and artists. The Center for Advanced Visual Studies (CAVS) was founded in 1967 at the Massachusetts Institute, united artists, scientists, and engineers around interdisciplinary work at the intersection of art and technology. Both institutions stand among the pioneers of early research on automatic image generation.

[6] - Paglen, Trevor (2020), "Conversation by Kate Crawford and Trevor Paglen", Training Humans, Fondazione Prada, Milan.

[7] - These new models follow in the lineage of technological inventions that have contributed to paradigm shifts in the status of the image (such as photography or computer graphics).

[8] - The latent spaces of major generative AI models are structured by commercial logics, embedded in specific cultural and economic contexts, and subject to various forms of surveillance and restriction that determine the control, value, and reach of cultural images (Somaini, 2025).

[9] - The dataset is used to train a machine learning model for the works Mosaic Virus (2018) and Mosaic Virus (2019).

exhibiting 10,000 annotated photographs as a 50-m² grid, she restores a tangible materiality to the dataset, revealing that information is, first and foremost, physical, and exposing the often-invisible human labor behind collecting, sorting, and categorizing [11]. The erasures and corrections visible on the annotations beneath each photograph reinforce the artisanal dimension while questioning the situated, subjective, and unstable nature of any classification system [12]. Ridler's idiosyncratic method of indexing exposes her own choices and reveals algorithmic biases, showing that images generated by artificial intelligence are never raw data but always the product of interpretation. The choice of the tulip also contributes to this act of revealing, it references Ronald Fisher's Iris dataset [13], linked to eugenic theories, reminding us that datasets carry cultural and ideological biases. By using the dataset underlying GANs as an artistic material, Ridler extends the reflections of modern art on the impact of material on form and meaning. At the same time, by making her process of constitution visible [14], she underscores the persistent opacity of the "black box" of machine learning models and the ethical issues associated with it.
Adversarially Evolved Hallucinations and *Myriad (Tulips)*, by experimenting with the processes of artificial image creation to apprehend the technical structures of neural networks, also reveal the social mechanisms that underlie them. In this sense, these works function as laboratories, first, through their production processes, the construction of the statistical image via the exploration of its latent spaces and materiality, and second, by linking this construction to their critical dimension. By questioning the regime of artificial images, these works demonstrate that machine learning models, far from being neutral, convey a normalization of values and ideologies, such as the amplification of surveillance logics, the diffusion of colonial biases, the standardization of forms, or energy extractivism (Ackerman et al., 2025; Crawford & Paglen, 2021; Noble, 2018).

Detecting Bias and Questioning the Real

Based on the premise that the absence of neutrality is inherent to machine learning systems (Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018; Dietschy, 2023), the automated interpretation produced by artificial intelligence necessarily entails political implications. Indeed, once integrated into social institutions and the devices that structure everyday life, AI contributes to the production and dissemination of norms and assignments that deeply influence collective representations.
As previously discussed, datasets constitute both the foundation of machine learning systems and the vectors and amplifiers of these political, ideological, and historically constructed biases (Benjamin, 2019; Crawford & Bury, 2022; Steyerl, 2025). In 2019, with *ImageNet Roulette*, Kate Crawford and Trevor Paglen examined existing datasets in order to detect and make visible the biases they produce and to demonstrate their limitations in generating falsely "objective" images. Visitors are invited to submit a photograph of themselves, which is then labeled and categorized by a machine learning model trained on ImageNet [15], a dataset widely used in computer vision research. The artists specifically explore the "person" category, not initially intended in the dataset's creation, yet carrying numerous prejudices [16]. The classification of portraits reveals racist, sexist, or homophobic attributions, demonstrating that ImageNet's data processing relies on contested categories such as race (a social construct varying across contexts) or gender, reduced to a binary conception.
The work thus demonstrates, through the direct involvement of the viewer, that artificial intelligence can amplify social stereotypes and that classification criteria are social constructions transformed into computational parameters. Like *Myriad (Tulips)*, though focusing on existing datasets, *ImageNet Roulette* also highlights the "click workers", often located in regions of the world under precarious working conditions, thereby questioning the ethics of classifying individuals, a process that objectifies and quantifies people. Initially conceived as an online interface denouncing the use of images without consent, *ImageNet Roulette* saw its reflexive dimension reinforced when it was taken down for copyright-related reasons. Presented today as an art installation, the work functions as a critical experimental dispositif, establishing

[10] - Anna Ridler establishes a parallel between datasets and encyclopedias, both of which, according to her, claim objectivity while being shaped by cultural, ideological, and material choices.

[11] - This refers to precarious human labor outsourced to "click workers" tasked with labeling images collected online in order to clean and standardize datasets.

[12] - The limits of any classification, based on arbitrary and incomplete criteria, are heightened by the fact that many entities remain undescribed, complicating their detection and classification by current systems.

[13] - In 1936, British statistician Ronald Fisher introduced a dataset based on morphological variations in iris flowers to illustrate his theory of linear discriminant analysis, aimed at predicting class membership from characteristics expressed through predictive variables. The dataset would later be used in numerous statistical classification techniques within machine learning programs.

[14] - Anna Ridler notes that an opacity persists once the tulip photographs are distilled into synaptic weights: the output still retains certain inexplicable aesthetic constants, such as the predominance of red in the generated images.

[15] - The ImageNet dataset maps a vast range of objects and is widely used for object recognition in machine learning.

[16] - Individuals identified may be classified according to their economic status, nationality, behavior, or even morality, with pejorative labels such as "bad person" or "failure". Similarly, terms such as "hermaphrodite", "crazy", or "prostitute" are used in stigmatizing ways.

an analytical distance from its tools and unveiling the extractivist logics underpinning AI infrastructures. In this sense, *ImageNet Roulette* aligns with what Jean Paul Fourmentraux defines as an “art of sousveillance” that operates as a laboratory for reflecting on the social, political, and economic contexts of contemporary technological transformations (Fourmentraux, 2023).

Beyond the stereotypes inherent in AI-generated images, their massive production and dissemination influence cognitive biases and shape behaviors. This phenomenon exemplifies hypernudging (Arruabarrena & Nesvijevskaia, 2024), which emerges from the scaling-up of nudges [17] made possible by machine learning and large-scale data extraction. Through profiling and hyper-personalization, it raises major ethical concerns, notably a loss of autonomy and an automation of choices directed toward economic or political ends. In response, several researchers emphasize the need to develop a strong and accessible critical apparatus to better understand the mechanisms and implications of AI. With *Slop Machine* (Fig.2), Albertine Meunier and Olivain Porry explore the massive dissemination of AI-generated images on the Internet and illustrate the phenomenon of hypernudging. The installation integrates an automated Instagram account where an AI model [18] continuously comments on, validates, and likes *slop* [19] streams, while visitors can interact with each image by pressing a red or green button to decide whether to like it or not. This participatory aspect invites viewers to examine each *slop* individually and to reflect on its capacity for visual saturation, often exploited for economic or political influence. The installation also attempts to categorize these contents according to consumption, politics, or satire. Thus, Albertine Meunier and Olivain Porry use *slop* both as material and as the subject

[17] - In social sciences, “nudge theory” refers to mechanisms that encourage individuals or groups to modify their behaviors or choices through influence rather than coercion or violence.

[18] - *Slop Machine* uses a generative LLM multimodal (Gemma 3), a large language model capable of processing and combining multiple input data types (text, image, and sound) to produce a generated textual response.

[19] - *Slop* is an English term referring to the abundance of low-quality images, sounds, and texts, mostly created by AI, that have become increasingly common online since 2022 with the democratization of text and image generators such as ChatGPT or Midjourney.

Fig. 1 - Albertine Meunier et Olivain Porry, *Slop Machine*, 2025, generative installation. Source: Albertine Meunier, Olivian Porry

of the work, making its mechanisms visible, from its aesthetic construction to its effects. Designed to maximize visibility and exploit platform algorithms, *slop* displaces the notion of the image. It is no longer produced to be true or beautiful, but to attract attention and saturate the visual space, thereby blurring the boundaries between the authentic and the artificial. In this sense, *Slop Machine* goes beyond the mere decoding of artificial intelligence, offering a critical reflection on post-truth and the political-economic logics facilitated by the spread of digital technologies.

In both *ImageNet Roulette* and *Slop Machine*, the exhibition space becomes a critical laboratory in which the viewer contributes to constructing a critical apparatus for the uses of AI, confronted directly with its reflexive dimension. Through a joint exploration of the scientific and sociological dimensions of machine learning models, these works move beyond the simple questioning of reality and invite what artist Hito Steyerl calls "an ethical commitment to the real" (Steyerl, 2025), by mobilizing AI in a conscious and fully reflexive way.

Conclusion

Conceived as laboratories for the creation of the real, through the production of new forms and the mediation between scientific worlds and society, artworks also become fields of critical exploration that develop an analytical stance toward new technologies. Artists mobilize AI as a medium, a research field, and an object of inquiry, rendering its biases, opacity, and sociotechnical effects perceptible. Under these conditions, artworks contribute to greater legibility and awareness of AI's impact on our lives and environments, while sometimes enriching ongoing research on neural networks. In this sense, beyond their scientific aim, the exploration of AI processes and the questioning of categorization systems foster alterity in the face of the homogenization, standardization, and impoverishment of imaginaries induced by machine learning models. They also open the possibility of an ethical commitment to the real, while paradoxically embodying the notion of pharmakon (Fourmentraux & Menger, 2011; Stiegler, 2010). Artificial intelligence operates here as both a tool of emancipation and a means of control, remedy and poison simultaneously. The works examined embody this duality by turning generative tools against their own opacity, exposing the structural biases of large-scale deployed systems, and mobilizing AI to critique the effects of AI itself. In this sense, artistic practice does not neutralize the pharmakon, it renders it visible, critically and reflexively, and it is precisely by sustaining this unresolved tension that it calls for situated, conscious, and responsible uses of artificial intelligence.

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